The online gaming market in India has seen a dramatic expansion over the past few years. According to a report by EY and FICCI, revenues of the country's online gaming segment rose from Rs 7,900 crore in 2020 to Rs 11,900 crore in 2022, and are expected to touch Rs 15,300 crore by 2024. However, India commands less than 10 per cent of the global market share in VFX (visual effects) and animation, per the Confederation of Indian Industry and the Boston Consulting Group. Last year, the Centre had set up an Animation, Visual Effects, Gaming and Comics (AVGC) promotion task force, which, experts had said, would help build capacity and create 2 million jobs in the sector. The task force had also suggested launching a 'Create in India' campaign with a sharp focus on content creation.

Against such steps, the GST hike is being seen as a major setback. Several gaming start-ups have urged the Centre to reconsider its decision, contending that it will make India's online gaming sector unviable. A letter signed by the Mobile Premier League, WinZO and industry associations said the move has left the sector in distress and that it will have a devastating impact on companies, some of whom may even be forced to shut down. The move will lead to a 400-500 per cent increase in the GST burden, which the industry "will have no choice but to pass on to 400 million Indians", the letter said, adding that it can also lead to the proliferation of the underground black economy.

As things stand, there is no clarity yet on whether the Centre will take these concerns into account. The cards, for now, seem stacked against the online gaming segment. ■

SCA ERADICATION

# A SICKLE-SHAPED MALADY

By Rahul Noronha

A July 2021 paper published in the *Indian Journal of Medical Research* suggests that India has the second highest prevalence of Sickle Cell Anaemia (SCA) with around 20 million people affected by the genetically transmitted disorder. Though official figures are unavailable, Madhya Pradesh is said to top the list among the states, so it was perhaps appropriate that Prime Minister Narendra Modi launched the SCA Elimination Mission on July 1 at Shahdol in the eastern part of the state. The mission hopes to eradicate the scourge of SCA by 2047, the 100th year of India's independence.

SCA is a blood disorder that impacts the red blood cells and is passed on from parents to children.

**THE MISSION'S HEALTH 'KUNDALIS' HOPE TO CREATE AWARENESS ABOUT SICKLE CELL ANAEMIA AMONG MARRIAGE PARTNERS**

A permanent cure has eluded medical science till now. The mission approaches this conundrum at two interacting levels: macro and micro. The first, here, denotes wide coverage: 17 states and 278 districts. Dr Sudam Khade, commissioner, MP health services, says, "In the absence of a national-level programme, individual states were tackling the disease on their own. Now, we will have additional funds and work on the eradication of SCA will proceed as per guidelines with greater inter-state cooperation. Work on both diagnosis and management will get an impetus."

The interesting part is at the micro level: a health card will be created for individuals that's virtually a new kind of *kundali*, based on tests on 'vulnerable populations'. Officially called genetic counselling cards, it will have the bearer's details on whether he/she has SCT (Sickle Cell Trait) or SCD (Sickle Cell Disease). The *kundali* has an advisory explaining to bearers whom they can marry and whom they can't. For example, a person with SCD should not marry someone with SCD as it will ensure the child born to them gets SCD. The Union government hopes to screen 70 million people in the 0-40 age group and create *kundalis* for them.




**CHANGE MAKERS** PM Modi inaugurates the Sickle Cell Anaemia (SCA) Elimination Mission in Shahdol, MP, July 1